

From Reporting to Execution: Diagnosing Accountability, Trust, and Planning Gaps in a Scaling Organization

TASK A : Diagnosis

Situation A – The Alert Nobody Responds To

1. What is the stated problem?

“The company has a functioning alert system that sends daily status reports to leadership. Despite this, the same red items remain unresolved for days and nobody escalates them. The CEO believes he still lacks visibility.”

2. What is actually going on underneath?

I don't think the CEO's complaint about visibility should be taken literally. The company already has a daily alert system, and the CEO can clearly see which departments are red. The more interesting question is why the same red items remain unresolved despite everyone being aware of them.

Right now, the alerts create awareness, but they don't create ownership. When a task is assigned to a department like "Warehouse" or "Purchase" instead of a specific person, accountability becomes unclear. Everyone can see the issue, but nobody feels directly responsible for taking action or escalating it.

Another thing I noticed is that the alerts are mostly reporting what has already gone wrong. The CEO's frustration suggests he is looking for earlier signals that help him understand what is happening on the floor before delays become visible in a report. In other words, the system is good at highlighting outcomes, but not at helping people intervene before those outcomes occur.

Over time, the current setup unintentionally encourages passive observation rather than active ownership. People receive information, but the process does not clearly drive action, accountability, or escalation.

The organization has become reasonably good at identifying problems. What it has not yet built is a consistent way of ensuring that those problems are owned, escalated, and resolved.

3. Evidence from the scenario

- The CEO says the same red items stay visible for days and nobody escalates them.
- The advisor points out that the tracker shows departments instead of individual owners.
- The email shows status and overdue days, but it doesn't show who owns the task, what action has been taken, or whether it has already been escalated.

All of this tells me that information is available, but ownership is unclear.

My conclusion is that information is not the scarce resource in this situation. The company already has visibility into many of its operational issues. The bigger challenge is converting that visibility into

ownership, escalation, and follow-through.

Situation B – The Blank Field

1. What is the stated problem?

Anil and Karthik believe that supervisors are not disciplined enough to fill out the root cause field properly. As a result, many entries are either left blank or filled with generic responses such as "under investigation" or "process deviation."

2. What is actually going on underneath?

I don't think this is a discipline problem.

I think it is a trust problem.

The two supervisor's comments completely changed how I see this situation. Both supervisors know what went wrong, but they have learned from experience that documenting the real reason can create problems for them or for someone else.

One supervisor mentions that writing the real root cause leads to lengthy questioning and blame during review meetings. Another supervisor explains that after a maintenance manager was publicly called out for an honest root-cause entry, people became reluctant to document issues truthfully.

From the supervisor's perspective, leaving a field blank is often the safer option.

What looks like poor documentation is actually self-protection.

The company wants the root cause field to be a learning tool. The supervisors appear to see it as a potential source of blame. Because of that difference in perception, the same field serves two completely different purposes depending on who is looking at it.

I also think Anil and Karthik missed the real issue because they focused on the visible symptom—the blank field—instead of asking why someone would intentionally avoid filling it. They interpreted the behavior as a compliance problem when it was actually a response to the environment around the process.

The behavior itself makes sense. If honesty increases scrutiny and creates uncomfortable conversations, people will naturally become selective about what they write down.

3. Evidence from the scenario

- Around 70% of root cause fields are blank or contain generic responses such as "under investigation" or "process deviation."
- Supervisor 1 explicitly states that writing the real cause leads to questioning and blame in review meetings.
- Supervisor 2 explains that after a manager was publicly called out following an honest root-cause entry, people stopped documenting root causes honestly.

- The same pattern appears across multiple departments, suggesting that this is not an individual discipline issue but a broader behavioral response.

All of this tells me that the problem is not a lack of knowledge about what went wrong. The problem is that employees do not feel completely safe documenting what went wrong.

My conclusion: The organization is asking employees to be transparent, but some of its existing behaviors unintentionally discourage transparency. As a result, the root cause field is not revealing what people know—it is revealing what people feel safe saying.

Situation C – The Meeting That Eats the Day

1. What is the stated problem?

The daily status meeting is scheduled for 30 minutes but regularly runs for 60–90 minutes. Technical issues consume a significant portion of the discussion, and new work identified during the meeting disrupts the rest of the day's activities.

2. What is actually going on underneath?

I don't think this is primarily a meeting problem.

The meeting is simply where a deeper problem becomes visible.

The biggest clue for me was when the advisor asked to see the daily plan and discovered that no daily plan existed. The organization has monthly plans and weekly plans, but no structured way of defining what success looks like for a specific day.

Because of that, nobody can clearly distinguish between planned work and unplanned work.

When a machine breaks down, a vendor misses a deadline, or a client introduces a new requirement, these events enter the day without any framework for understanding their impact. Everything immediately becomes urgent because there is no baseline plan to compare against.

As a result, the daily meeting has gradually become much more than a status meeting. It has become a planning meeting, a problem-solving meeting, an escalation meeting, and sometimes even a decision-making meeting.

The technical discussions are not causing the long meetings. The lack of planning discipline is forcing those discussions into the meeting.

Another thing I noticed is that the company is not tracking unplanned work in a structured way. Problems appear, people react to them, and the day moves on. But nobody is consistently asking why these disruptions occurred, how often they occur, or whether the same disruptions keep repeating.

This creates a cycle of firefighting. The organization spends a lot of time responding to issues but learns very little from them.

To me, long meetings are not the root cause. It is a symptom of an organization that is managing work reactively rather than proactively.

3. Evidence from the scenario

- The advisor discovered that neither Anil nor the department heads maintain daily micro-plans.
- The company has monthly and weekly planning, but no daily planning structure.
- The tracker does not break complex activities into smaller tasks or show dependencies between tasks.
- Technical discussions that should involve only a few people are happening in a meeting attended by all twelve department heads
- The advisor specifically notes that unplanned work is not being categorized, tracked, or linked back to root causes.
- The output of the meeting creates additional unplanned work for the rest of the day.

All of this suggests that the meeting is exposing weaknesses in planning and execution rather than creating them.

My conclusion

The long meeting is therefore not the problem itself. It is simply where the consequences of weak daily planning, unclear dependencies, and unmanaged unplanned work become visible. As a result, the daily meeting has become the place where planning, coordination, escalation, and problem-solving all happen at once. The long meeting is therefore not the problem itself—it is a visible symptom of weak daily planning and a lack of structure around unplanned work.

PART B: Intervention Design

Situation A – The Alert Nobody Responds To

1. First Conversation

My first conversation would not be with the CEO. I would spend time with 2–3 HODs whose departments regularly appear in RED and understand what happens after they receive the alert.

Instead of asking about the report itself, I would ask them to walk me through a real example.

"I saw that this item has been RED for the last few days. When you first saw it, what did you think needed to happen?"

"If you wanted to close it immediately, what would stop you?"

"Who else would need to act before you could move this forward?"

I want to understand whether the issue is ownership, dependency on another department, lack of authority to make decisions, or simply that nobody knows what action is expected after the alert appears.

The goal of this conversation is not to fix the report. It is to understand why a RED status does not naturally lead to action.

2. What Changes in the First 2 Weeks

Before introducing any new tool, I would change how RED items are discussed.

Today, the conversation is around departments. I would shift the conversation toward ownership and next actions.

For every RED item, we should be able to answer four questions:

- Who owns this?
- What is the next action?
- What is blocking progress?
- When will the next update be available?

I would also stop reviewing every item every day. Instead, the discussion would focus only on:

- Newly created RED items
- Items that have remained RED for more than three days
- Items blocked by another department

The objective is to move people from reporting status to discussing actions and dependencies.

3. System / Tool Design

What the User Sees

Instead of a department-level alert, the user sees a task-level view.

For example:

PO Approval | Owner: Ramesh | Status: RED | Open for 4 Days | Waiting on Finance Approval

The focus is no longer "Purchase Department is RED."

The focus becomes:

"Why is this task stuck and what is preventing closure?"

I would also include:

- Owner name
- Blocking dependency
- Last update date
- Number of days in RED status

This gives context rather than just color coding.

Workflow

1. The owner updates the status of the task.
2. If blocked, the owner selects the blocking department or person.
3. If the task remains RED for more than three days without progress, the system flags it.
4. The escalation is visible to both departments involved.
5. The CEO receives a summary of unresolved blockers rather than a list of all RED items.

The purpose of the workflow is to expose bottlenecks, not generate more notifications.

Technology

I would continue using Excel because it has already been adopted by the HODs and previous software implementations have failed.

Power Automate would be used only for exception-based alerts and escalation reminders.

The technology is intentionally simple because the behavioural problem is more important than the software problem.

4. Buy-In from a 15-Year Supervisor

I would not start by showing him a tracker.

I would ask him to show me one activity that regularly gets delayed even though his team completed their part.

After listening, I would say:

"Right now, when this delay appears in the report, management only sees that it is pending. They don't see that your team finished its work two days ago and is waiting on someone else."

"If we can make that dependency visible, the conversation changes from 'Why is this delayed?' to 'What is preventing this from moving forward?'"

My intention is to show him that the system is not being introduced to monitor him. It is being introduced to make operational reality visible.

If he sees that the system helps surface genuine bottlenecks instead of creating more reporting work, adoption becomes much easier.

Situation B – The Blank Root Cause Field

1. First Conversation

My first conversation would be with the two supervisors who openly admitted that they avoid documenting the real root cause.

I would not begin by asking why the field is blank. Instead, I would ask them to walk me through the last deviation they handled.

I would ask:

"When the deviation happened, what did you believe the actual cause was?"

"What made you decide not to write that in the tracker?"

"What happened the last time someone documented the real reason?"

I would then separately speak with the maintenance head and QA manager involved in those examples.

My objective is to understand whether people are hiding information because of fear of blame, damaged relationships between departments, or previous experiences where honest reporting created negative consequences.

2. What Changes in the First 2 Weeks

For the first two weeks, I would not change the form.

I would change how deviations are discussed.

Whenever a deviation is reviewed, the discussion would begin with:

"What conditions allowed this to happen?"

instead of

"Who caused this?"

I would also introduce a simple rule:

Every deviation discussion must identify:

- Immediate cause
- System cause
- Preventive action

The conversation should move away from assigning fault and toward understanding the process breakdown.

I would specifically look for one or two examples where an honest root cause leads to a meaningful process improvement and highlight those examples publicly.

The goal is to demonstrate that reporting the truth leads to support and learning rather than criticism.

3. System / Tool Design

What the User Sees

Instead of a single "Root Cause" box, the supervisor sees:

Deviation:

What happened?

Immediate Cause:

What condition allowed this to happen?

What support is needed to prevent recurrence?

Owner:

The form guides people toward thinking about the process rather than defending themselves.

Workflow

1. Supervisor records the deviation.
2. HOD reviews and validates it.
3. If a deviation remains unresolved for more than a defined period, it is flagged.
4. Corrective actions are assigned to named owners.
5. Monthly reviews focus on recurring patterns rather than individual incidents.

Technology

I would continue using Excel because supervisors already use it and previous software adoption attempts have failed.

Power Automate would only be used to remind owners about unresolved corrective actions.

Claude would be used at the end of each month to identify recurring themes across deviations and summarize patterns for leadership.

4. Buy-In from a 15-Year Supervisor

I would sit with the supervisor and ask him to explain a deviation that he remembers well.

After listening, I would say:

"From what you're describing, the issue wasn't simply a mistake. There were conditions that made the mistake possible."

"Right now the report only shows the deviation. It doesn't show the missing spare part, the dependency, or the pressure your team was working under."

"My goal is to make sure those realities become visible so the same issue doesn't happen again."

If he sees that the process captures operational reality instead of creating a blame trail, he is far more likely to participate honestly.

Situation C – The Meeting That Eats the Day

1. First Conversation

My first conversation would be with Anil and Karthik.

I would ask them to walk me through the previous day's meeting from start to finish.

For every topic discussed, I would ask:

"Was this planned work, routine work, or unplanned work?"

"What happened afterward?"

"Did anyone record why this became urgent?"

My objective is to understand whether the meeting is solving problems or acting as a place where planning failures become visible.

2. What Changes in the First 2 Weeks

I would not shorten the meeting immediately.

Instead, I would change what is allowed into the meeting.

Every item discussed must be categorized as:

- Routine work
- Planned work
- Unplanned work

Technical investigations, deep problem-solving discussions, and department-specific troubleshooting would be moved into separate follow-up sessions.

The daily meeting would focus on:

- Status changes
- New risks
- Blockers
- Escalations

I would also introduce a simple practice:

Whenever unplanned work appears, someone must record why it appeared.

After two weeks, we should be able to identify recurring causes of disruption.

The goal is not to reduce meeting time.

The goal is to reduce the amount of unplanned work entering the organization.

3. System / Tool Design

What the User Sees

A daily planning sheet divided into three sections:

Routine Work

Planned Work

Unplanned Work

Every task has:

- Owner
- Priority
- Dependency
- Expected completion date

The objective is to make today's commitments visible.

Workflow

1. Departments update their daily priorities before the meeting.
2. During the meeting, only exceptions and blockers are discussed.
3. New unplanned work is logged immediately.
4. At the end of the week, recurring sources of unplanned work are reviewed.
5. Leadership receives trend reports showing where disruptions originate.

Technology

Excel would be used because the organization is already comfortable with it.

Power Automate would generate a daily summary of blockers and unplanned work trends.

Claude would analyze historical data and identify recurring patterns behind disruptions.

The technology exists to support planning discipline, not replace it.

I am intentionally designing the tool to capture why work is not progressing, not simply whether it is progressing. The company already knows when tasks are late. The missing information is why they become late in the first place.

4. Buy-In from a 15-Year Supervisor

I would not tell him that the meeting is too long.

Instead, I would ask:

"How much of yesterday's work actually happened as planned?"

Most experienced supervisors immediately know when their day is being consumed by unexpected issues.

I would then say:

"I'm not trying to add another planning sheet. I'm trying to understand why work that was supposed to happen today keeps getting replaced by firefighting."

"If we can identify the recurring causes of disruption, your team spends less time reacting and more time executing."

This positions the process as a way to protect his team's time rather than as an administrative exercise.

PART C: Scale Thinking

1.What breaks first?

The first thing that breaks is not the tracker or the meetings. It is the organization's dependence on individual follow-up as a mechanism for execution.

Today, when a task stalls, Anil or Karthik notices it, follows up, reminds people, clarifies dependencies, and pushes the work forward. Many activities are being completed because someone is actively chasing them.

This works with two projects because the volume is manageable.

At eight projects, the number of dependencies, deviations, approvals, and exceptions will increase significantly. No analyst will be able to keep all of that in their head.

The risk is that execution becomes dependent on who is following up rather than on a repeatable operating system.

The evidence is visible in the scenario itself. Both Anil and Karthik describe spending most of their time following up, attending meetings, documenting actions, and ensuring people do what they committed to do. That indicates the process still relies heavily on manual intervention.

2. What system would I build?

Not a tracker, everyone will build a tracker.

I'd build: **Commitment-to-Closure System**

Every commitment made in:

- daily meeting
- deviation review
- project review

must contain:

Commitment	Owner	Next Action	Dependency	Date
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More importantly:

The system would not measure how many tasks exist.

It would measure how many commitments are repeatedly failing and why.

For example:

Commitment	Owner	Dependency	Date	Status
Vendor approval	Purchase	QA review	June 5	Delayed
QA review	QA	Stability report	June 4	Blocked

When a commitment misses its date, the owner cannot simply update the status.

They must select one of the following:

- Waiting on another department
- Resource unavailable
- Unplanned deviation
- Priority changed
- Incorrect estimate
- Other

Over time, the company starts collecting data not just on delays, but on the reasons behind delays.

3. Automate vs Human

I'd make it more nuanced.

Automate

- Reminder generation

- Escalation triggers
- Trend analysis
- Repeated deviation pattern detection
- Weekly summary creation

Keep Human

- Root cause discussions
- Daily planning
- Escalation conversations
- Negotiation between departments
- Supervisor coaching
- Priority decisions

Then add this line:

"I would avoid automating any process that currently lacks trust. Automation scales behavior. If the underlying behavior is poor, automation will only help the organization repeat the same mistake faster."

Why this matters at 8 projects

Today, Anil and Karthik know the reason behind most delays because they spend their day following up with people.

At eight projects, that knowledge cannot remain inside individuals' heads.

The Commitment-to-Closure System converts tribal knowledge into organizational knowledge.

Instead of asking:

"Why is this late?"

Leadership can ask:

"Why do 40% of delayed commitments involve QA approvals?"

The focus shifts from managing individual tasks to managing recurring bottlenecks.

What it looks like in practice

Every morning:

- HODs review open commitments.
- New commitments from meetings are added.
- Blocked commitments are identified.

- Escalations happen automatically based on predefined rules.

Every Friday:

The analyst reviews:

- Which commitments were completed?
- Which commitments failed?
- What were the recurring reasons?
- Which departments appear repeatedly as blockers?

The discussion becomes about patterns rather than individual incidents.

Why I would build this before scaling

The company already has trackers, dashboards, and reports.

What it does not yet have is a reliable mechanism that connects:

Commitment → Ownership → Dependency → Closure

As the company grows from two projects to eight, I believe this connection becomes more important than any dashboard because execution failures will increasingly occur at the handoff points between teams rather than within a single department.

Bonus Point Insight

I'd include:

One thing that stood out to me was the failed adoption of PDGMS. The company already experimented with a structured planning approach but abandoned it after three months before restarting it again. Before introducing any new process, I would investigate why adoption dropped. If a structured planning system could not sustain usage with two projects, that problem will become significantly larger at eight projects.